Women among IISER and IISc Faculty

A data study of regular faculty, NIRF 2019 to 2026 · iGEM IISER Kolkata 2026 · Inclusivity

Background

Women are about 28% of researchers worldwide [1] and under 15% in India [2]. Faculty are who students meet in class and in the lab. Studies in the US suggest that seeing women in these roles can influence what women go on to study [3–5].

Aims

To describe, from public data, how many women are regular faculty at the IISERs, how this has changed since 2019, who has been joining, and what the data can and cannot tell us about why.

Results

- Women are 14.4% of regular faculty at IISER Kolkata (18 of 125). Across the seven IISERs the range is 12.0% (Berhampur) to 23.2% (Tirupati), and together they are 18.8% (148 of 788). IISc Bangalore, for reference, is 10.0%.
- Kolkata's share has barely moved: between 13.8% and 14.4% in every one of eight yearly lists since 2019. Pune rose from 17.6% to 21.8% and TVM from 10.2% to 19.5%.
- Of Kolkata's net growth in regular faculty since 2019 (17 people), 3 were women (18%). The corresponding share was 43% at Pune and 30% at TVM.
- Among faculty at the six other IISERs, the share of women rises with the period of joining: 14%, 18%, 22% and 26%. At Kolkata it does not (15%, 12%, 16%, 13%), though the groups are small.
- Women are a smaller share of faculty than of undergraduates at every IISER. The gap is 32 points at TVM and 13 at Kolkata. Across institutes, the two shares are only weakly related (r = 0.22, n = 7).

Introduction

Our companion study looked at who enrolls at the IISERs. This one asks who teaches there. The two questions are connected. Worldwide, women are about 35% of higher-education STEM students but about 28% of researchers [1], and in India under 15% of researchers [2]. Somewhere between the classroom and the research career the share falls, and faculty posts are one of the places where it can be seen.

Faculty also matter to students directly. Several studies at US universities found that women who were taught by women, or who met a woman from their field, were more likely to continue in that subject [3–5]. These studies come from other settings and measure particular courses, and we do not know how far the results carry over to Indian institutes. We cite them as a reason to look, not as evidence about the IISERs.

The National Institutional Ranking Framework (NIRF) [6] asks each institute to list its faculty, with gender, designation and type of appointment. From those lists we ask four questions. How many women are regular

faculty? Has the share changed? Who has been joining? And how do the faculty numbers compare with the student numbers?

This study describes. It does not show why any institute's share is what it is, and it says nothing about individual people. Explanations are marked as questions to test.

Our dataset

Each NIRF submission contains a "Faculty Details" table with one row per person: designation, gender, qualification, joining and leaving dates, whether the person is currently working at the institute, and the type of association (regular, contractual, visiting or other). We read this table from 42 of the 44 available datasets. Mohali 2020 and IISc 2018 have no faculty table.

A script converted the rows into a single table of 7,400 entries. For all seven IISERs, the number of regular, currently working women and men in the latest file agrees with a separate line-by-line count of the PDF text. The data was also manually checked by the team.

Definition used throughout. "Regular faculty" means a person marked as currently working whose association type is Regular. This excludes contractual, visiting and "other" appointments, which are used inconsistently across institutes and years (Section 6). Percentages are of people, not of full-time posts.

THE DATABASE AT A GLANCE

All details are given in IISER_faculty_data.xlsx (counts by institute, year, rank and joining period)

Table 1. The NIRF year is the year of submission, so each count is a snapshot of one list.

Institute	Files	NIRF years	Regular faculty, latest
Kolkata	8	2019-26	125
Pune	8	2019-26	142
Mohali	6	2019, 2021-25	115
TVM	7	2020-26	113
Tirupati	2	2025-26	69
Berhampur	3	2024-26	50
Bhopal	1	2026	174
IISc	7	2020-26	482

How to read the figures. Each list is a snapshot as submitted by the institute and is not independently audited. Gender is recorded only as male or female. The tables count every listed person, so they are not samples and we report no confidence intervals or significance tests. The numbers are small: at the smaller institutes a single appointment moves the share by 1 to 2 points, and the groups in Sections 3 and 4 are often below 30 people. Differences of a few points should not be over-read. The data do not give the department or field of each person, so we cannot say whether women are concentrated in particular subjects.

Main findings

1. A low share everywhere, and large differences between institutes

In the latest list, women are 23.2% of regular faculty at Tirupati, 21.8% at Pune, 20.1% at Bhopal and 19.5% at TVM. Mohali has 17.4%, Kolkata 14.4% and Berhampur 12.0%. No IISER is above one in four. The range is about 11 points, compared with about 25 points for students.

Pooled across the seven IISERs, women are 18.8% (148 of 788). Excluding Kolkata the figure is 19.6%. IISc Bangalore, which is much larger, is 10.0%, so the IISERs sit above the institute they are most often compared with.

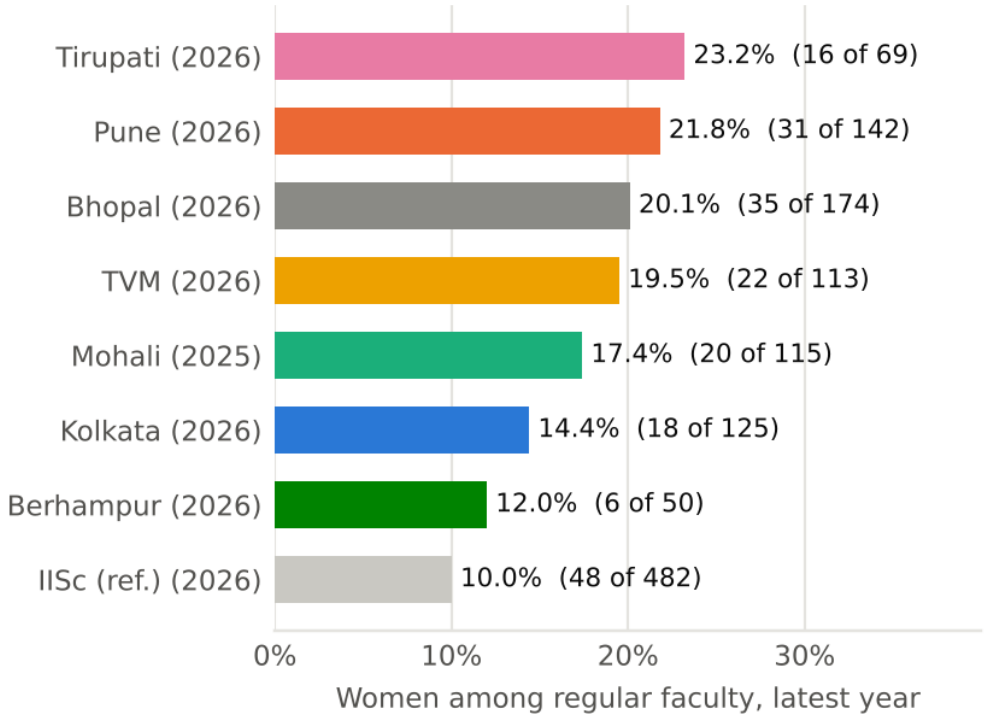


Figure 1: Women among regular faculty, latest NIRF list. Labels give the share and the count of women out of all regular faculty. Mohali's latest list is 2025.

In absolute numbers the picture is starker. Kolkata has 18 women among its 125 regular faculty. Pune has 31, Bhopal 35, TVM 22 and Mohali 20. Only Tirupati (16) and Berhampur (6) have fewer, and both are much smaller institutes.

To reach the 19.6% of the other six institutes at its present size, Kolkata would need about 7 more women (18 to 25). We give this only to show the scale of the gap.

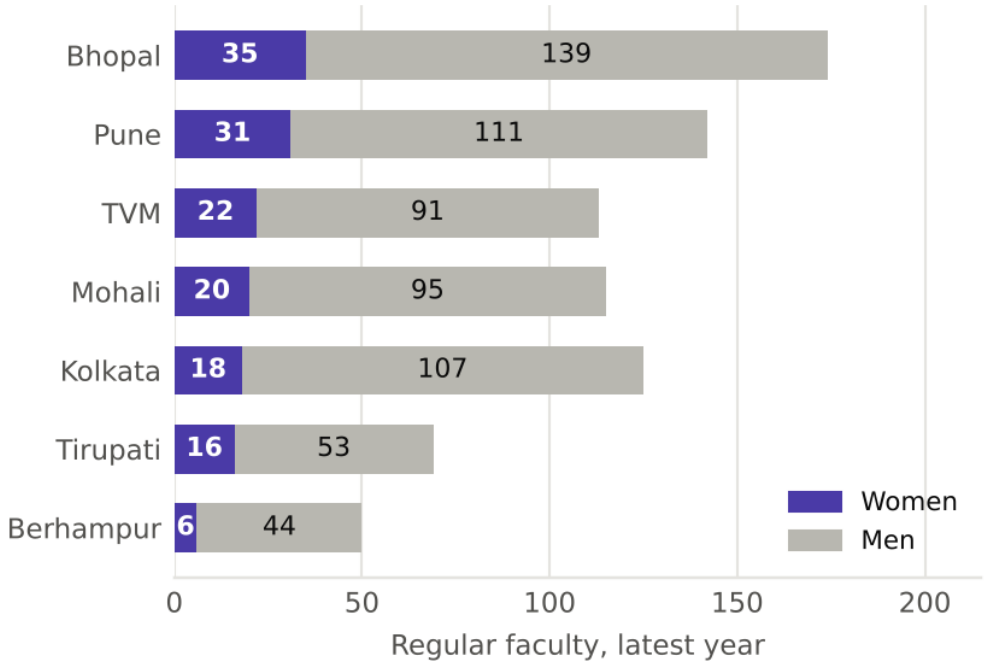


Figure 2: Number of women and men among regular faculty, latest list. Violet: women. Grey: men.

2. Change since 2019 has been uneven

Kolkata has been almost flat: 13.8% to 14.4% across all eight lists, while the number of regular faculty grew from 108 to 125.

Pune rose from 17.6% to 21.8%. **TVM** nearly doubled, from 10.2% in 2020 to a peak of 21.7% in 2024 (92 people), then 20.8% in 2025 and 19.5% in 2026, when the list grew by seven people, all men. **Mohali** moved from 16.5% to 17.4%.

Tirupati, Berhampur and Bhopal have too few lists to describe a trend.

IISc rose from 7.7% in 2020 to 10.0% in 2026. Its 2021 dip comes partly from 86 people being classed as contractual in that list, so we treat it with caution.

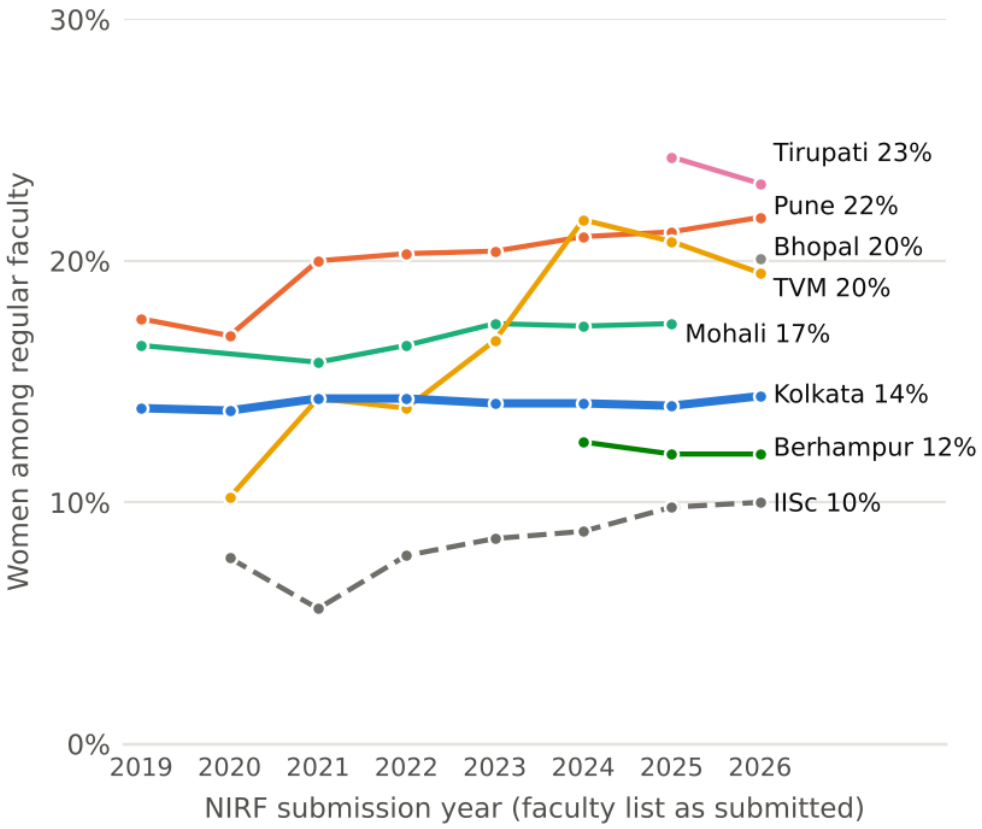


Figure 3: Women among regular faculty over time. One point per NIRF list. Mohali has no 2020 list, so its line joins 2019 and 2021. Dashed: IISc.

Table 2. Women among regular faculty, first and last list available.

Institute	Lists	First (%)	Last (%)	Change (points)	Regular faculty (headcount)
Kolkata	2019 to 2026	13.9	14.4	+0.5	108 to 125
Pune	2019 to 2026	17.6	21.8	+4.2	119 to 142
Mohali	2019 to 2025	16.5	17.4	+0.9	91 to 115
TVM	2020 to 2026	10.2	19.5	+9.3	59 to 113
Tirupati	2025 to 2026	24.3	23.2	−1.1	70 to 69
Berhampur	2024 to 2026	12.5	12.0	−0.5	40 to 50
IISc	2020 to 2026	7.7	10.0	+2.3	440 to 482

However, the headcount matters here. TVM grew from 59 to 113 regular faculty in six years and Kolkata from 108 to 125 in seven. A growing faculty is the main chance to change the balance, because new posts can shift the share faster than turnover can. We return to this in the next section.

Bhopal has no change shown because we have only its 2026 list.

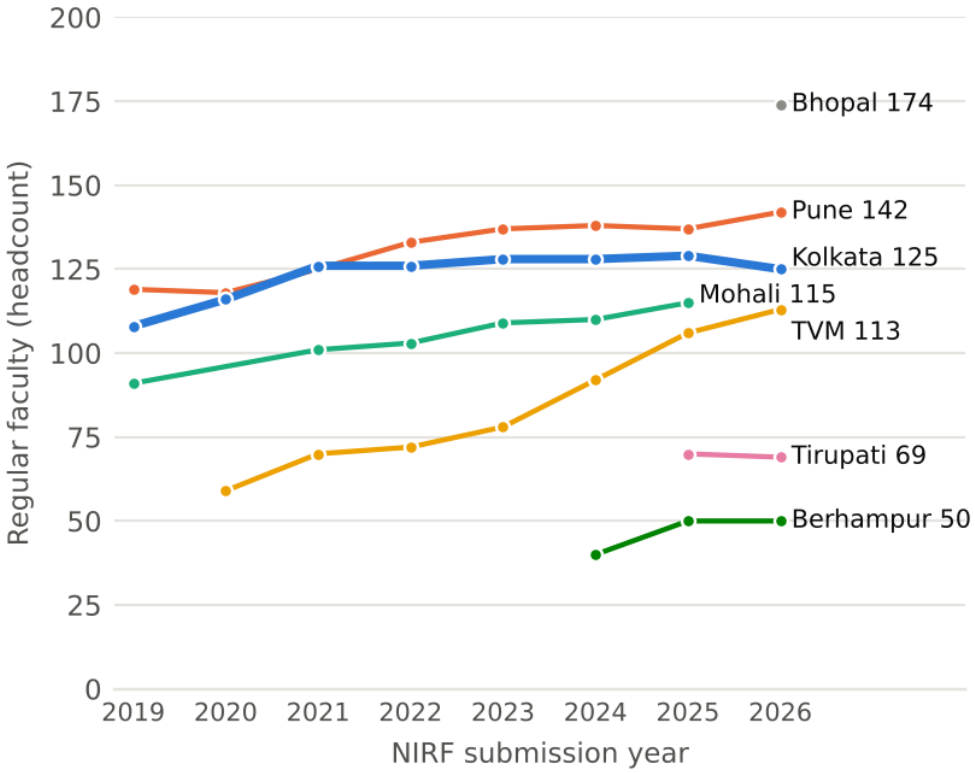


Figure 4: Regular faculty headcount over time. Counts of people listed as regular and currently working in each NIRF list.

3. Who has been joining?

Counting the net change in regular faculty shows where the added posts went. At Kolkata, 3 women and 14 men were added between 2019 and 2026, so 18% of the growth was women. At Pune it was 43% (10 women, 13 men) and at TVM 30% (16 women, 38 men). At Mohali it was 21% and at Berhampur 10%.

These are net changes between two lists, so they combine hiring with departures. At every institute except Berhampur, women were a larger share of the growth than of the starting faculty. But Pune and TVM added many women (10 and 16), while Kolkata added 3 and Mohali 5, so the share moved far less at the latter two.

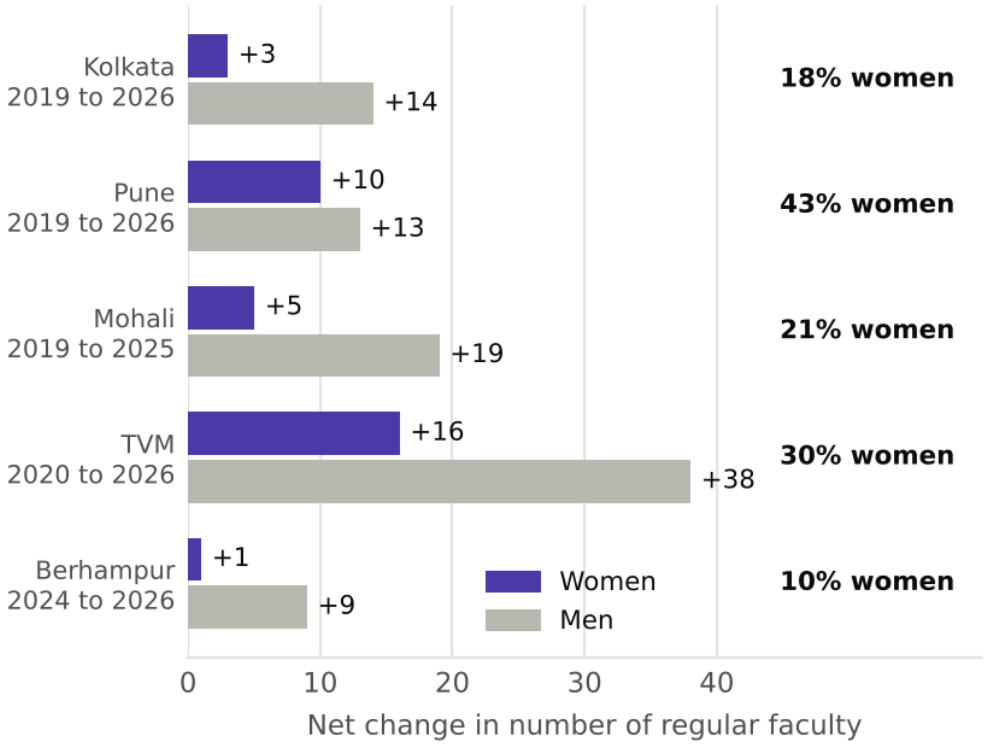


Figure 5: Net change in regular faculty, women and men. Bold: share of the net growth that was women. Periods differ by institute.

A second view uses the date each person joined. Among people on the latest list at the six other IISERs, the share of women is 14% for those who joined up to 2012, 18% for 2013-17, 22% for 2018-21 and 26% since 2022. Hiring appears to have moved towards women over time.

At Kolkata the pattern is flat: 15%, 12%, 16%, and 1 woman among the 8 who joined from 2022. Taking everyone who joined from 2013, Kolkata has 8 women of 59 (14%), against 104 of 476 (22%) at the other six.

Note: We could only count people who are still on the list, so anyone who joined and left is invisible, and if women left sooner or later than men the cohorts would look different from the people actually hired. Kolkata's cohorts are also small (8 to 66 people), so the difference between its recent cohorts and the others is suggestive, not conclusive.

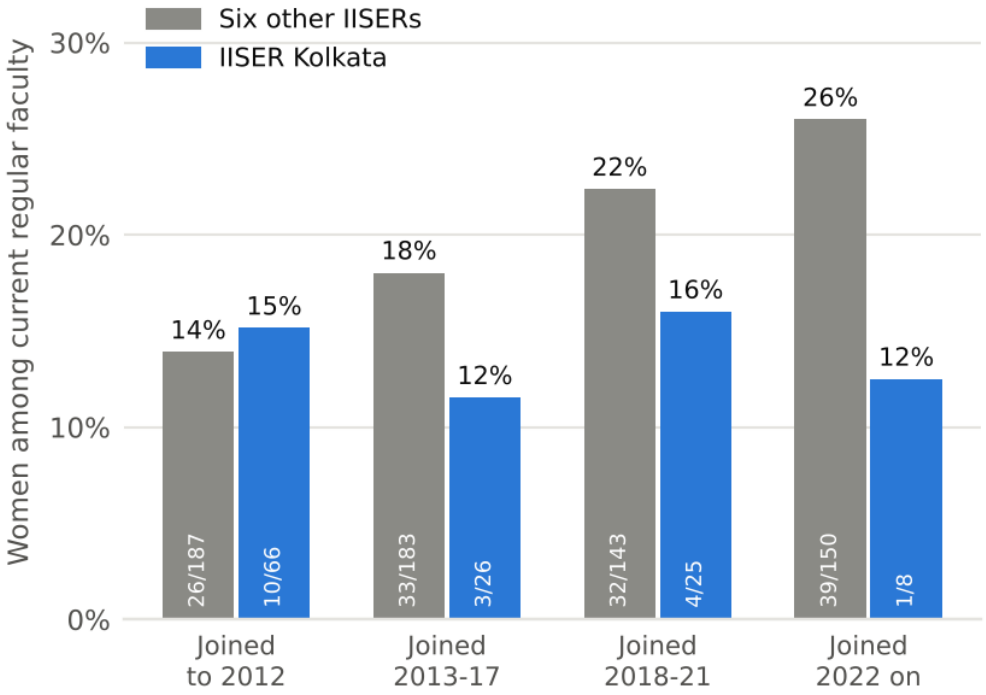


Figure 6: Women among current regular faculty by period of joining. Counts of women/total on each bar. "Six other IISERs" pools Pune, Mohali, TVM, Tirupati, Berhampur and Bhopal.

4. Seniority

Across the six other IISERs, women are 23% of assistant professors, 20% of associate professors and 12% of professors and above. At IISc the same figures are 15%, 10% and 5%.

Kolkata differs: 17% of assistant professors (3 of 18), 11% of associate professors (3 of 28) and 15% of professors and above (12 of 79). It has a relatively strong senior group. The women professors are mostly among the people who joined up to 2012.

Note: This is just one analysis from us, not a career path. The lower share at senior ranks mostly reflects who was hired one or two decades ago (Section 3). These data cannot tell us whether women are promoted more slowly or leave more often, since that needs the same people followed across years.

**"Professor and above" includes people whose designation in the list is a dean or director title, which the NIRF form does not separate from rank.*

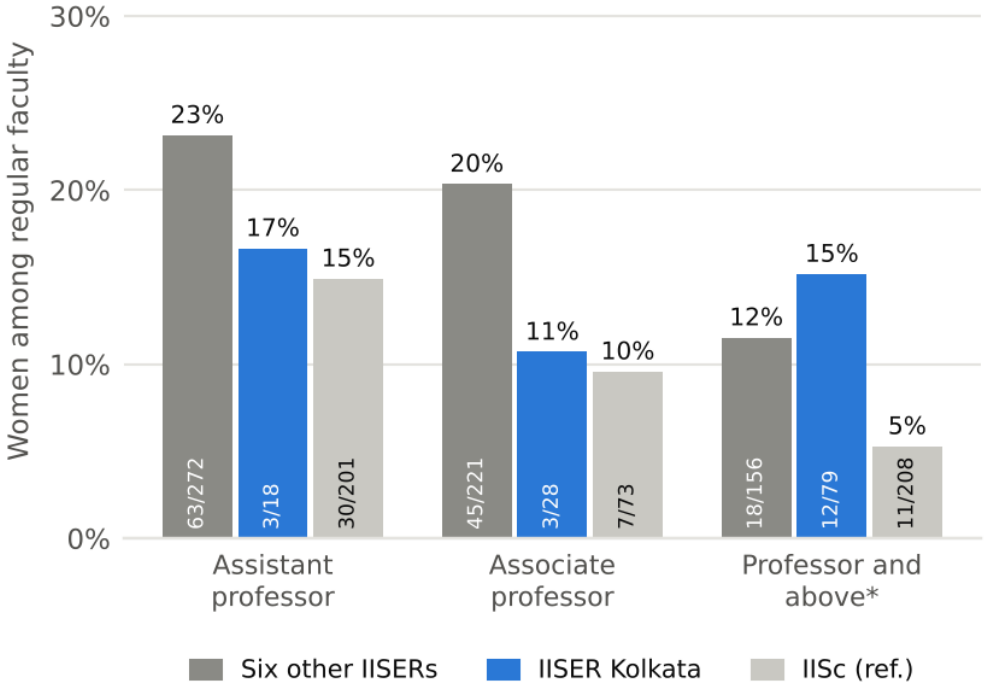


Figure 7: Women among regular faculty by rank, latest list. Counts of women/total at the foot of each bar.

5. Faculty and students compared

At every IISER, women are a smaller share of faculty than of undergraduates. The gap is 6 points at Pune, 13 at Kolkata, 19 at Bhopal, 23 at Mohali, 29 at Tirupati, 32 at Berhampur and 32 at TVM. Kolkata's gap is among the smaller ones only because its student share is itself low.

The student share is the latest five-year programme figure from our companion study (2024-25, except Mohali 2023-24).

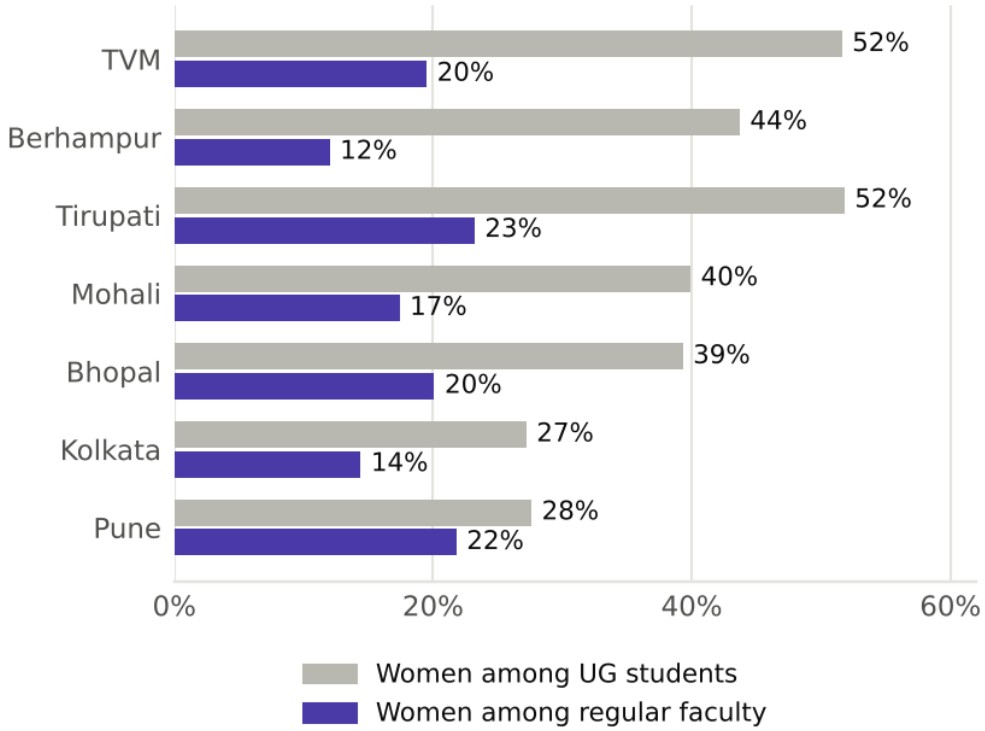


Figure 8: Women among UG students and among regular faculty, latest year. Grey: share of UG five-year students. Violet: share of regular faculty.

The two shares are only weakly related across institutes (r = 0.22, n = 7). The institutes with the most women among students, TVM and Tirupati, have faculty shares of 20% and 23%. Kolkata and Pune are low on both measures, and Berhampur is low on faculty only.

This should of course not be read as "students become faculty" because that is untrue. Faculty, in India, are recruited nationally and independently after a PhD and often a postdoc, so the pool that matters is PhD students and postdoctoral researchers by gender. NIRF does not report that split, and it is the most important missing piece.

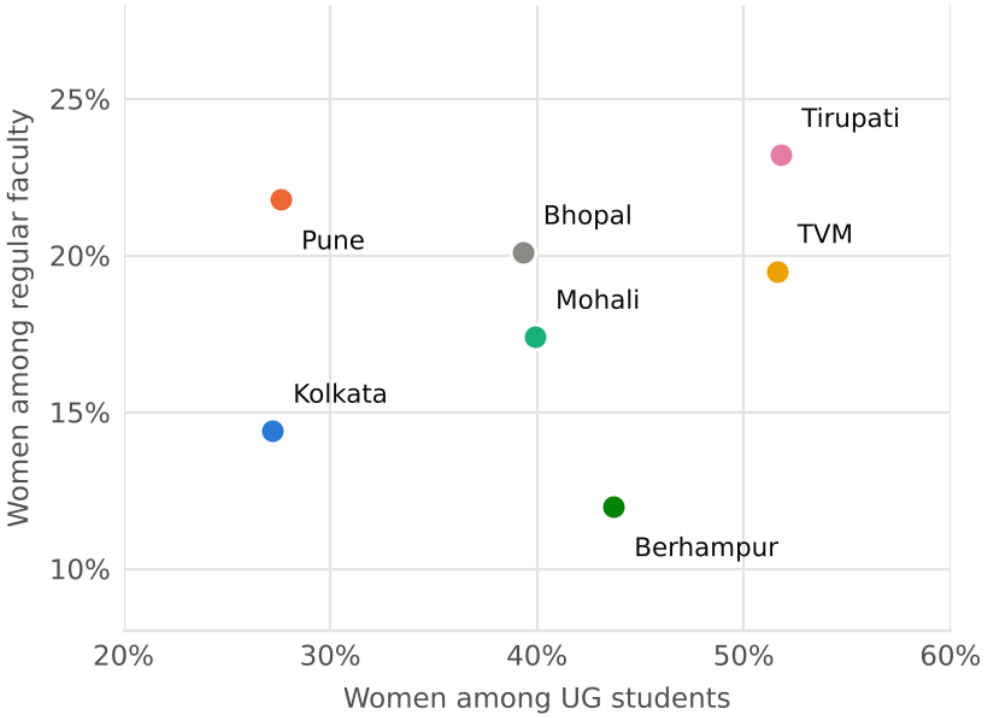


Figure 9: Women among UG students and among regular faculty, by institute. Each point is one institute, latest year.

6. Regular posts and other posts

Besides regular faculty, the lists include people in contractual, visiting and "other" appointments: 61 at the seven IISERs in their latest lists. 16 of them (26%) are women, against 18.8% of regular faculty. This is a small group and the types are used differently by different institutes (for example Berhampur lists 6 visiting faculty in 2026, and Tirupati lists 23 non-regular people), so we do not draw a conclusion. It would be worth asking whether women are over-represented in non-permanent posts. Kolkata lists none.

What it adds up to

Supported by these data

- Women are a minority of regular faculty at every IISER (12.0% to 23.2%) and a smaller share than among undergraduates at each one.
- IISER Kolkata is in the lower half (14.4%), with 18 women, and its share has been flat since 2019 while its faculty grew.
- At other institutes the share of women among more recently joined faculty is higher. At Kolkata it is not clearly so.
- Shares are lower at senior ranks, mostly because the senior cohorts joined long ago.

Not supported or not testable

- Why Kolkata's hiring looks different. Possible reasons include the number and mix of women applicants, how positions are advertised and reviewed, which fields were hiring, and chance (the groups are small). These are questions, not findings. We have returned to this question later in our work.
- Whether women leave or are promoted more slowly. That needs the same people followed across years, or the institutes' own records.
- Anything about PhD students or postdocs by gender, or about the field of research.
- Anything about people not recorded as male or female.

Clues to improve balance

The data do not explain the gaps, but they suggest where to look.

Looking at recruitment: The cohort pattern at the other IISERs suggests that hiring has changed. It can be asked what those institutes did differently, for example in how posts are advertised, how search committees are formed, and how many women apply.

Lessons from Pune and TVM: Both added women at or above their existing share while growing. They are the closest examples of what an expanding faculty can do.

Looking at the junior pipeline: Kolkata has 3 women among 18 assistant professors. Whether women are applying, being shortlisted and accepting offers is a question for the institute, not for us, but it is the first one to ask.

Connecting to students: Our student study found that Kolkata and Pune enrol the lowest share of undergraduate women. Faculty visibility may be one factor students weigh. However, that is an unproven hypothesis. Asking current students would test it. That is what we aim to do via our interview process.

Recommendations

We offer these as proposals to discuss with the institute, with NIRF and with future teams.

For the IISERs

- The number of applicants, shortlisted candidates, offers and joiners for faculty positions can be published yearly, by gender.
- PhD students and postdoctoral researchers by gender can be reported, so the pipeline into faculty posts can be seen. However, we understand that the same cohort of PhD students and postdocs do not enter the interview process for faculty positions. Hence, we refrain from drawing any premature conclusions for the same.
- The exits and promotions by gender can be tracked, with anonymised records, and reviewed each year.

For NIRF

- The association types can be defined clearly and applied uniformly, so that regular and non-regular posts can be compared.
- A gender split for PhD students and postdoctoral researchers, and the field or department of faculty can be reported.

For us and future teams

- Rerun the script each year and extend it to other NIRF institutes.
- With ethics approval, there can be interviews and surveys for students and faculty about how visible women faculty are in their experience. We have already done this. The results are recorded in later sections of the wiki.

Literature

[1] UNESCO. (2017). Cracking the code: Girls' and women's education in science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM). Paris: UNESCO. https://www.unesco.org/en/articles/new-unesco-report-sheds-light-gender-inequality-stem-education

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[4] Carrell, S. E., Page, M. E., & West, J. E. (2010). Sex and science: How professor gender perpetuates the gender gap. Quarterly Journal of Economics, 125(3), 1101–1144.

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[6] National Institutional Ranking Framework (NIRF), Ministry of Education, Government of India. Data submitted by institutes, "Overall" category, 2019 to 2026. https://www.nirfindia.org

Attributions

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This study was designed and carried out by Dixita Adhikari of iGEM IISER Kolkata 2026.

Appendices

Appendix A. Women among regular faculty, (number of regular faculty)

Institute	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Kolkata	13.9 (108)	13.8 (116)	14.3 (126)	14.3 (126)	14.1 (128)	14.1 (128)	14.0 (129)	14.4 (125)
Pune	17.6 (119)	16.9 (118)	20.0 (125)	20.3 (133)	20.4 (137)	21.0 (138)	21.2 (137)	21.8 (142)
Mohali	16.5 (91)	–	15.8 (101)	16.5 (103)	17.4 (109)	17.3 (110)	17.4 (115)	–
TVM	–	10.2 (59)	14.3 (70)	13.9 (72)	16.7 (78)	21.7 (92)	20.8 (106)	19.5 (113)
Tirupati	–	–	–	–	–	–	24.3 (70)	23.2 (69)
Berhampur	–	–	–	–	–	12.5 (40)	12.0 (50)	12.0 (50)
Bhopal	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	20.1 (174)
IISc	–	7.7 (440)	5.6 (378)	7.8 (464)	8.5 (482)	8.8 (476)	9.8 (481)	10.0 (482)

A dash means no list was available for that institute and year.

Appendix B. Sensitivity: all currently working faculty, any appointment type, % women

Institute	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Kolkata	13.5 (111)	13.7 (117)	14.2 (127)	14.2 (127)	14.0 (136)	13.7 (131)	14.0 (129)	14.4 (125)
Pune	20.0 (130)	17.8 (129)	19.0 (137)	20.4 (142)	20.4 (142)	21.4 (145)	21.1 (142)	23.7 (152)
Mohali	22.3 (103)	–	19.1 (110)	20.2 (114)	18.8 (112)	17.7 (113)	17.6 (119)	–
TVM	–	10.9 (64)	13.9 (72)	15.4 (91)	18.8 (96)	21.3 (94)	23.7 (118)	19.5 (128)
Tirupati	–	–	–	–	–	–	25.3 (79)	23.9 (92)
Berhampur	–	–	–	–	–	14.3 (42)	13.8 (58)	12.5 (56)
Bhopal	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	19.8 (177)
IISc	–	7.7 (440)	7.5 (464)	7.7 (465)	8.5 (482)	8.8 (476)	9.8 (481)	10.0 (482)

Using all appointment types in place of regular faculty changes the Kolkata series by under 1 point in every year. At some other institutes the difference is larger (Mohali 2019: 22.3% against 16.5%), which is why we use regular faculty as the main measure.

Appendix C. Files used

Faculty tables were read from 42 of the 44 NIRF PDFs: Kolkata 2019 to 2026 (8), Pune 2019 to 2026 (8), Mohali 2019 and 2021 to 2025 (6), TVM 2020 to 2026 (7), Berhampur 2024 to 2026 (3), Tirupati 2025 and 2026 (2), Bhopal 2026 (1), IISc 2020 to 2026 (7).